GOA

THE FIRST GOANS ASK A QUESTION

By Dhaval Kulkarni



Tribal communities in Goa are becoming increasingly vocal about their political and social rights. Over the past few months, they have upped the ante on one of their long-pending demands—10 per cent political reservation for scheduled tribes (STs) in the Goa legislative assembly and have threatened to boycott the 2024 Lok Sabha polls if this was not met. In 2003, the Gauda, Velip and Kunbi communities were added to the ST category. Though STs and Scheduled Castes (SCs) have 12 and two per cent quotas respectively in jobs and education, tribals still do not have political reservation. However, SCs have one seat reserved for them in the house—Pernem in North Goa.

"We have been deprived of our rights for the last 20 years...if tribals are elected as MLAs from seats reserved for us, they'll raise issues related to us in the assembly," says Govind Shirodkar, spokesperson of the Mission Political Reservation for Scheduled Tribes of Goa, which is spearheading the demand. In addition to the poll boycott, the group, formed in 2022 by tribal organisations in Goa, has also threatened widespread protests if the political quota does not materialise. "The quota may come into effect in the 2027 Goa state assembly election, but we want the notification to be issued (by 2024)," Shirodkar says. The association has launched an awareness campaign in areas with substantial tribal presence. Mission Political Reservation is also seeking the implementation of the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, formation of a tribal advisory council (TAC), and declaration of scheduled areas.

The state has four tribal MLAs—speaker Ramesh Tawadkar (Canacona), sports minister Govind Gaude (Priol) and Ganesh Gaonkar (Sanvordem) of the BJP, and independent MLA Antonio Vas (Cortalim), who has announced his support for the BJP.

Political quota for tribals is an emotional issue. In May 2011, a protest by the United Tribals Associations Alliance (UTAA) at Balli, around 50 km from state capital Panaji, turned violent, and two tribal youths—Dilip Velip and Manguesh Gaonkar—were burnt alive. They are regarded as martyrs to the cause. The assembly polls in 2012 saw a tribal backlash against the then

CRY FOR QUOTA

- The Gaudas, Kunbis and Velips trace their origins to the earliest aboriginal inhabitants of Goa
- They were added to the ST list in 2003. Smaller tribal groups include Dubla, Siddi, Naikda, Varli, Dhodia
- STs form around 10.23 per cent of Goa's population
- SCs have 2 per cent reservation in jobs and education, while it is 12 per cent for STs
- In April 2022, Mission Political Reservation for Scheduled Tribes of Goa was launched